Establishing a cohesive and coherent command and control system commanded enormous attention on the part of US and Soviet political leaders and military planners throughout the Cold War and after.

The dangers of an unreliable or insufficient C2 system in North Korea are chilling to contemplate. The decision to use American nuclear weapons is initiated solely by the president, with orders confirmed and transmitted through the secretary of defense and chairman of the Joint Chiefs of Staff, and there is little reason to assume that Kim Jong-un would allow anything less. But the chain of authority in the US system is clear, from the president to the secretary of defense and chairman of the Joint Chiefs, and then through the National Military Command Center to the commander of Stratcom. How or if Kim will delegate authority down his chain remains unknown. Kowalski, the former deputy commander of Stratcom, asks, "Who [in North Korea] will have authority to order a warhead mated onto a missile? Who has authority to target? Arm it? Launch it?"

Even before launch orders are issued, each stage of getting a nuclear weapon ready for use, from taking the warhead out of the bunker, to mating it to the missile, to targeting and launching, is fraught with the potential for miscommunication and mechanical accident of the kind described earlier. The more launch systems on alert or fully armed and fueled, the higher the probability for some kind of error over time. As former Stratcom commander Haney asks, "How do you know that nuclear weapons will be taken out only when you want them to be, or that you have a trusted teamwork approach?"

The use of nuclear weapons, whether authorized or unauthorized, begins with arming a missile and making it ready for launch. Except for the small number of weapons on alert, US missiles are kept separate from their nuclear warheads, and an order must be given to move the warheads out of secured storage bunkers to be matched with the delivery systems. Given that a good part of Kim's arsenal involves road-mobile missiles, the time required to move them to safe launching locations may push the North Koreans to keep more warheads outside secured storage, either regularly mated to missiles or quickly accessible nearby.